

Why do it?

ENEMY OF THE STATE?

Over the door of the farmhouse we built as soon as we had enough money to build a proper house, we chiseled the words of Virgil: “*Hic domus, haec patria est.*”

Roughly translated: This is our home; this is our country. But when you say it, you have to put the emphasis on the second “THIS.” Then it makes sense.

“This is our home” is a statement of fact.

“THIS is our country” is practically treason.

It is to the state, not the family, that people pledge allegiance. The state ministers not only to peoples’ material needs, but also to their psychological and emotional desires. In the time of war, for example, a citizen puts his own interests subordinate to the interests of the state. If he is called upon to give up his life or his treasure to the war effort, he is ready to do so, content that the sacrifice was noble.

In peacetime, national elections are viewed as great contests in which the individual wins or loses, along with his candidates. When his party wins, the voter wins. He feels not only that he will get what he wants but that his enemies will get it too!

When national health care was instituted, for example, those who favored it must have walked with a bounce in their step, even though they had contributed nothing to the campaign and had no idea whether or how it would actually improve the health care of the nation. They were sure it was the right thing for themselves and others, even those who didn’t approve of it.

Historians will note that modern times are much more like the imperial days of Rome than the days of the Roman Republic. In our quote, Virgil (partly to please Augustus) was still talking about the virtues of the republic, during which time families were still more important than the central government of Rome. The republic was dominated for hundreds of